



The Altitude Mindset

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A FIELD GUIDE

7 Patterns That Keep *High Performers* Stuck

What each pattern looks like from the inside, why it formed, and the first question to ask yourself to start loosening it.

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You are not the problem. The pattern is.

For ten years my job in aviation was to watch people work under pressure and assess what I saw. Not in a classroom — during live operations, where the stakes were real and nobody performs for an assessor for very long.

After enough of that, you stop seeing individuals and start seeing patterns. The same handful, over and over. The capable one who freezes. The competent one who over-explains. The person who was right and said nothing.

What struck me was that none of it correlated with ability. These were skilled people. What was running them was something older and quieter: a conclusion drawn once, in a situation that mattered, and never revisited since.

That is what a pattern is. Not a character flaw. Not a discipline problem. A response that made complete sense when it formed, and has been running on autopilot ever since — including in situations it no longer fits.

Below are the seven I see most often in ambitious, high-performing people. As you read, notice which ones produce a flicker of recognition. That flicker is the useful part. **You cannot change a pattern you cannot see.**

The seven.

Read them in order the first time. They are arranged from the most internal to the most visible, and several of them feed each other.

01 The Competence–Confidence Split

You are demonstrably good at it, and it still doesn't feel that way

02 Analysis as Avoidance

Where thinking stops being thinking

03 The Protective Reaction

What your strongest reaction is guarding

04 The Pre-emptive No

Declining before anyone gets the chance to

05 The Softened Sentence

Saying it so carefully that it stops being true

06 The Rerun

The same argument in a different costume

07 The Knowing–Doing Gap

Why knowing what to do isn't enough

01

The Competence–Confidence Split

FROM THE INSIDE

You have the results. The record is there and you can point at it. And none of it reaches the part of you that decides how you feel walking into the room. You brace before meetings you are the most qualified person in. Praise slides off; one piece of criticism sticks for a week. Some part of you has quietly classified your track record as luck, timing, or other people being generous.

WHY IT FORMED

Confidence and competence are built by different mechanisms. Competence accumulates from doing the work. Confidence is a belief about yourself — and beliefs are not updated by evidence alone, only by evidence you actually let count. Most high performers install a rule early on that keeps them moving: *this one doesn't count yet*. It is an excellent engine for effort. It also means the goalposts move every single time you reach them, so the internal scoreboard never changes no matter what the external one says.

WHAT IT COSTS

You work harder than the situation requires, because the work is doing two jobs — the task, and the reassurance. That is expensive, and it does not stop being expensive as you get better.

THE FIRST QUESTION

“What would I have to have already done for this to count — and have I done it?”

02

Analysis as Avoidance

FROM THE INSIDE

It feels like diligence. You are considering angles, stress-testing, being responsible. But the loop has stopped producing anything new — you are turning over the same four considerations, and each pass feels like progress while the decision stays exactly where it was. Then someone asks what you have decided, and the honest answer is that you have been very busy not deciding.

WHY IT FORMED

There is a real line between thinking and overthinking, and it is not about duration. **Thinking generates new information. Overthinking recycles existing information.** The moment a loop stops producing anything new, it has changed function: it is no longer solving the problem, it is managing the discomfort of not having solved it. And it works — that is the trap. Deliberating feels materially better than committing, because commitment is where being wrong becomes possible.

WHAT IT COSTS

Decisions get made anyway, just later and by default. Delay is a choice that gets to feel like caution.

THE FIRST QUESTION

“In the last hour of thinking about this, what did I learn that I didn’t already know?”

03

The Protective Reaction

FROM THE INSIDE

The size of the reaction does not match the size of the event, and you know it — usually about ninety seconds too late. A particular tone, a particular kind of question, being interrupted, being corrected in front of someone. Something fires before you have any say in it, and you spend the evening reviewing a thirty-second exchange.

WHY IT FORMED

A reaction that size is not about the present event. It is a defence built for something earlier that genuinely required defending, and it is still on duty. The reaction is not irrational — it is *out of date*. This is the pattern people are hardest on themselves about, and it is the one that deserves it least: at some point, that response was the intelligent thing to do.

WHAT IT COSTS

Trying to suppress it does not work, because suppression addresses the reaction rather than the trigger. The leverage is in noticing the state earlier, while it is still small enough to interrupt.

THE FIRST QUESTION

“If this reaction is protecting me from something, what does it think is about to happen?”

04

The Pre-emptive No

FROM THE INSIDE

You did not apply. You did not put your name forward. You mentioned the idea in a way engineered to make it easy to dismiss, then felt something like relief when it was. Asked why, you have a reasonable answer ready — the timing, the workload, not quite the right fit. The reasoning is sound. It also arrived after the decision.

WHY IT FORMED

Being rejected by someone else is a different experience from removing yourself, even when the outcome is identical. One happens to you; the other you control. Fear of failure rarely announces itself as fear — it arrives dressed as realism, as good judgement, as not wanting to waste anyone's time. That is what makes it hard to catch: it uses your own competence at reasoning to justify itself.

WHAT IT COSTS

A career of sensible-sounding declines, each individually defensible, adding up to a much smaller life than your ability accounts for.

THE FIRST QUESTION

“If I knew I’d be accepted, would I still say no for this reason?”

05

The Softened Sentence

FROM THE INSIDE

You had something specific to say. What came out was hedged, qualified, wrapped in enough padding to be deniable — and then you were quietly frustrated that it did not land. Or the reverse: you finally said it, and it came out with a decade of accumulated pressure behind it, and the force became the story instead of the content.

WHY IT FORMED

Both are the same pattern. Softening and sharpening are both strategies for saying a difficult thing while managing what it might cost you. The softened version protects the relationship at the expense of the message. The sharpened version delivers the message at the expense of the relationship. Most people have a default, learned somewhere it was genuinely necessary.

WHAT IT COSTS

The third option — clear *and* kind — is a learnable skill, not a personality trait. In aviation this is not left to instinct: crews are trained to raise a concern in a way that is unambiguous and does not damage the working relationship, because the cost of getting it wrong is too high to leave to chance.

THE FIRST QUESTION

“What is the one sentence I actually mean — and what am I adding to it to make it safer?”

06

The Rerun

FROM THE INSIDE

It is nominally about the plan, or the money, or who said what. But you both know the choreography. You can predict their next line and they can predict yours, and you arrive somewhere you have been many times before. Different subject, identical shape.

WHY IT FORMED

When an argument recurs with that much fidelity, the stated subject is not the subject. Something underneath is unresolved, and each new topic is simply the vehicle available that day. Which is also why winning one never settles anything — you resolved the vehicle, not the cargo.

WHAT IT COSTS

The hard part is that you can only see your own half clearly, and your half looks like a response to theirs. But your half is the only half you can change — and in a loop this tight, changing one side reliably changes the shape of the whole thing.

THE FIRST QUESTION

“Strip out the topic — what is the shape of this argument, and where else does it show up?”

07

The Knowing–Doing Gap

FROM THE INSIDE

You know exactly what to do. You could explain it clearly to someone else, and your advice would be good. You are not doing it. And because you know what to do, the only available explanation seems to be that something is wrong with your discipline — which is a conclusion that makes the whole thing considerably worse.

WHY IT FORMED

Understanding a thing and being able to do it under pressure are different capabilities, stored differently. Insight lives in language. Behaviour lives in practice and in state. This is why reading more does not close the gap — you are adding to the part that already works.

Aviation is blunt about this. Under pressure people do not rise to the occasion; they fall to the level of what they have actually rehearsed. Nobody is expected to reason their way through an emergency from first principles. The response is trained until it runs without permission.

WHAT IT COSTS

Every unactioned insight becomes evidence against yourself. The gap is not a willpower problem. It is a rehearsal problem — and rehearsal is fixable.

THE FIRST QUESTION

“Have I ever actually practised this — or have I only ever understood it?”

Recognition is stage one of five.

If two or three of those landed, that is the useful outcome. Naming a pattern takes it off autopilot — which is genuinely something, and is not the same as changing it.

Recognition is where the work starts, not where it finishes. In my coaching it is the first of five stages:

01 Recognize

Name the pattern, the trigger, and the belief underneath it

02 Reframe

Challenge the interpretation the pattern is built on

03 Reset

Learn to change your emotional state deliberately, under pressure

04 Rewire

Build and rehearse the replacement response using practical NLP techniques

05 Rise

Apply it consistently until it is simply how you operate

You can do stage one from a document. Stages two to five need someone watching from outside the pattern — because from the inside, a pattern is very good at looking like reality.

THE NEXT STEP

Want to know which pattern is actually running you?

That is what the discovery call is for. Thirty minutes, no cost, no pitch — we work out what is really going on and whether coaching is the right tool for it. If it isn't, I'll tell you.

Book your free discovery call

calendly.com/hazikdijoo/30min · thealtitudemindset.com

AN HONEST BOUNDARY

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